

Question 14 · Unit 1 · 8 Marks

Analyse the changing role of an HRD professional as organisations move from traditional personnel administration toward strategic human resource development.

Introduction

Analyse the shift in role along several dimensions: from what to what, why the change happened, and what new competencies are needed. Traditional personnel work was administrative. Strategic HRD work is diagnostic, integrative and business-linked.

Detailed points

- 1. From record-keeper to diagnostician.** Earlier: maintain service books, training attendance, holiday lists. Now: analyse capability versus strategy, climate data and performance trends. The professional must ask ‘what people problem is blocking the business?’
- 2. From classroom organiser to learning architect.** Booking a guest lecture is old role. New role designs blended learning: OJT, coaching, e-learning, projects. Learning is a system, not an event.
- 3. From isolated training cell to integrator of subsystems.** Strategic HRD connects appraisal, potential, career, counselling and OD. The professional’s role is to make these talk to each other, which personnel clerks never did.
- 4. Business literacy and seat at the strategy table.** The HRD person must understand products, customers and competition enough to translate strategy into competencies. Role includes advising top management, not waiting for a training request from a department.
- 5. Change agent.** Mergers, digitalisation, quality and restructuring are people processes. The new role facilitates change, deals with resistance and redesigns culture — far beyond issuing transfer orders.
- 6. Partner who develops line managers.** Personnel often did things to employees. Strategic HRD does things with managers, making every boss a developer. The professional’s success is measured by managers’ coaching quality.
- 7. Accountability with metrics.** New role uses evaluation and HRD audit, not ‘number of programmes conducted’. This is uncomfortable but necessary for strategic status.
- 8. Why the change and remaining tension.** Competition and the idea of human capital forced the change. Tension remains: many organisations still want the old clerk plus a fashionable title. Analysis should note that the role changes fully only when top management treats HRD as strategic.

Conclusion. Show a clear before–after analysis of the role, give reasons (environment, strategy, human capital), and close with required new competencies: consulting, facilitation, business understanding, ethics.